

WHITFIELD COUNTY, GEORGIA • 2024 TAX DIGEST

The cap, the breakdown, and the correction

A resident-friendly, source-traced presentation of what happened, what it cost, what the

records prove, and what remains unproven.

The essential finding: the digest process failed and became a billing, refund, audit-control, and cash-flow problem. The records also show sharply reduced fiscal capacity—but they do not prove that the digest caused every dollar of that decline.

A visual story with an evidence binder behind it

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Documentation stack: this deck is accompanied by a reader guide, evidence binder, claim matrix, calculations schedule, source register, and preserved public-source exhibits.

A valuation dispute turned into a government cash-flow event

REPORTED

1. A limit was requested

Assessor-board representatives said elected officials requested a set percentage increase after values had already been developed.

REPORTED

2. The results looked uneven

Tax Commissioner Danny Sane cited large commercial reductions alongside steep residential increases and refused to sign.

PRIMARY RECORD

3. A court kept bills moving

The court authorized temporary billing from 2023 parcel values plus 10%, subject to specific exceptions.

AUDITED

4. The effects reached finance

Later corrections, mass refund funding, control findings, and a fully drawn \$6M TAN followed.

Bottom line: the failure is documented. A retailer-development motive, illegality, and complete digest-caused loss are not.

Every statement wears its evidence label

VERIFIED PRIMARY RECORD

Government record inspected directly

Court orders, DOR exports and reports, audited ACFRs, adopted budget, and official releases. “Verified” means the cited record says it—not that every implication is proved.

NAMED REPORTED STATEMENT

A named person was quoted

Useful and attributable, but the underlying letter, minutes, dataset, or recording may still be missing.

DERIVED CALCULATION

Arithmetic reproduced from cited inputs

The inputs are sourced; the result is an analyst calculation and is labeled as such.

LEAD / ALLEGATION

A claim still needs documentary proof

The county finance office account identifies testable issues. It is not presented as a public-record finding.

No fraud label

No unnamed-person identification

No causal leap

No combining unlike dollar amounts

No single official controlled the whole system

VALUATION

Board of Tax Assessors

Independent local valuation body; appraisal staff prepare parcel values and the digest.

BILLING

Tax Commissioner

Signs the digest, bills taxpayers, collects, refunds, and distributes taxes. Does not set parcel values.

REVIEW

Georgia DOR

Reviews digest compliance, millage submissions, ratios, and approval status.

CONTINUITY

Superior Court

Resolved the signature dispute and authorized temporary collection during the impasse.

Keep the lanes straight: valuation, billing, state review, and judicial continuity are different functions. A breakdown between them is not proof that one actor caused all resulting costs.

The tax base had already moved sharply

\$2.814B

2022 county M&O net taxable digest

DOR cell PD1715

\$3.497B

2023 county M&O net taxable digest

DOR cell PD1724

+24.2916%

One-year increase

+\$683,537,976

2021 collection



98.88%

2022 collection



100.00%

2023 collection



92.71%

Receipts: [P1] 2022 DOR export; [P2] 2023 DOR export; [P9] FY2023 ACFR p.162. Calculations: [C01–C02].

The disputed intervention—and the refusal

March 2024 • a percentage limit was requested

Gail Noles later said unnamed elected officials asked the former assessor-board chairman for a set percentage increase. She said the board accepted it and compressing completed values created “unexpected consequences.”

Later meeting • Jensen suggested “a small increase”

Jevin Jensen said he and Dalton Mayor Annalee Harlan Sams met with assessors. The reporting does not prove they were the unnamed March participants.

June 21–24 • Sane refused to sign

Reporting quotes Sane saying 800+ commercial/industrial accounts fell by more than \$50,000 while 7,000+ homes rose by more than 50%.

August 21–29 • mandamus

The assessor board sought a court order. A visiting judge reportedly compelled Sane to perform the ministerial act of signing.

The temporary digest was a bridge—not the final answer

STARTING POINT

2023

COURT RULE

+10%

Temporary increase

With explicit rules for sales/splits, physical changes, exemptions, and new property.

LATER STEP

True-up

Final certified digest

Later reporting and the assessor release support amended bills, credits, or refunds.

What the order proves

- An impasse prevented completion and approval.
- The delay threatened government and school cash flow.
- The Tax Commissioner was ordered to bill and collect on the temporary basis.

What it does not prove

- That every parcel simply received +10%.
- That temporary billing equaled overbilling.
- That 114 itself ordered refunds; it allowed amended tax bills after DOR approval.

The temporary values were replaced and the state record caught up

OFFICIAL RELEASE

All

June 2024 assessment notices replaced

Revised values produced March 11; replacement notices announced April 11 and mailed April 15, with a new appeal period.

DOR EXPORT

\$3.736B

April 1 DOR 2024 county M&O export

Cell PD1741; +\$238,679,323 / +6.8244% over 2023.

DOR REPORT

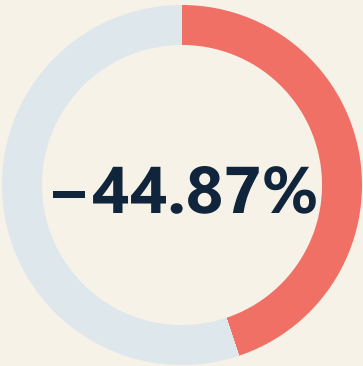
4.300

County M&O mills for 2024

Each figure answers a different question

FIGURE	CATEGORY	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT IT DOES NOT MEAN
\$1.956M	REPORTED AUTHORIZATION	Funding approved for refunds to roughly 9,000–10,000 taxpayers.	Not automatically net loss.
\$294,076	AUDITED CORRECTION	Decrease in government-wide beginning net position.	Not the same reporting level as fund balance.
\$366,798	AUDITED CORRECTION	Increase in General Fund beginning fund balance.	Not additive as a single net error with \$294,076.
\$477,571.58	SCALE ILLUSTRATION	Countywide 2023×110% base gap at 4.300 mills.	Not parcel-level reconciliation.
\$64,950	DIRECT TAN COST	\$50,250 interest plus \$14,700 issuance cost.	Does not include the repaid \$6M principal as loss.
\$4,888,626	BUDGET PLAN	Approved FY2026 planned use of fund balance.	Not a separately measured digest loss.

The flexible General Fund cushion fell sharply



FY2023 unassigned balance	\$34,765,919
FY2024 unassigned balance	\$29,462,476
FY2025 unassigned balance	\$19,165,540
Two-year decline	-\$15,600,379

Total General Fund balance

-\$12.193M

From \$35,335,153 to \$23,142,428: a **34.51%** decline.

Unassigned share of expenditures

60.8% → 27.0%

FY2023 to FY2025, as reported in the ACFR management analyses.

“About \$4 million” meant reduced fiscal capacity

THE ROUNDED DESCRIPTION, AS CLARIFIED

about \$4M

Jeff clarified that this referred to diminished capacity / anticipated reserve use—not a separate digest-loss schedule.

APPROVED BUDGET

\$4,888,626

The FY2026 resolution shows \$62,229,307 revenue and \$67,117,933 expenditures, with the difference explicitly labeled “Fund Balance.”

Correct interpretation: the official budget gives the exact planned draw. It is prospective budget authority, not proof that the same amount was spent, lost, or caused by the 2024 digest.

Reserve trend = audited fact

FY2026 draw = approved plan

Complete digest loss = not calculated

The annual statements contain more than digest effects

FY2024 AUDITED

General Fund flow

Revenue	\$55,878,499
Expenditures	\$61,328,112
Deficiency	\$5,449,613
Net other financing	+\$137,546
Net decrease	\$5,312,067

FY2025 AUDITED

General Fund flow

Revenue	\$57,859,651
Expenditures	\$71,645,575
Deficiency	\$13,785,924
Net financing	+\$6,539,068
Net decrease	\$7,246,856

The reserve decline establishes reduced capacity. The statements do not assign all of it to the digest; expenditures, transfers, debt, corrections, and other activity also matter.

The County borrowed the full \$6 million and repaid it

\$6,000,000

Principal borrowed

Entered September 30, 2025; fully drawn for delayed-digest cash flow.

\$6,050,250

Principal + interest repaid

Paid December 31 from 2024 property-tax receipts collected September–December.

\$64,950

Direct financing cost

\$50,250 interest plus \$14,700 issuance cost.

What this proves: delayed-digest cash-flow pressure was followed by actual short-term borrowing that was fully drawn. **What it does not prove:** that no other factor affected the borrowing decision, or that the

The control failure became explicit in FY2025

FY2024 FINDING 2024-001

Year-end close material weakness

Material adjustments and prior-period restatements were required. Separate findings covered segregation of duties, void approvals, and deposit delays.

This was not yet the digest-specific restatement finding.

FY2025 FINDING 2025-001

Digest reconciliation material weakness

The audit says temporary-versus-final digest differences were not identified and corrected timely. Management began reconciliation after audit inquiries.

Note 22 presents separate government-wide and General Fund corrections.

Unmodified audit opinions and material weaknesses can coexist: the financial statements may be fairly presented after audit corrections even when the underlying controls failed.

Where each major proposition stands today

PROPOSITION	STATUS	BEST EVIDENCE	REMAINING LIMIT
The 2024 digest process materially broke down.	VERIFIED	Court order, DOR review, replacement notices, audit finding.	Exact DOR workflow dates missing.
Elected officials sought a percentage limit.	REPORTED	Noles’s named statement.	Underlying March record and identities missing.
Sane refused over uneven parcel effects.	REPORTED	Quoted June letter and contemporaneous reports.	Signed letter/data not obtained.
The digest delay caused liquidity pressure.	AUDITED	FY2025 TAN disclosure.	Does not quantify every digest effect.
The County’s fiscal capacity fell sharply.	AUDITED	FY2025 comparative schedule.	Full decline is not assigned to digest.
A retailer-recruitment motive drove the cap.	UNVERIFIED	Finance-director account only.	No named parcel or documentary trail.

What can be said—and what cannot

Supported now

- ✓ A genuine digest and billing breakdown occurred.
- ✓ Political pressure over assessment levels was publicly acknowledged.
- ✓ Temporary court-authorized billing was required.
- ✓ Every June 2024 assessment notice was replaced.
- ✓ Refund funding and audit corrections followed.
- ✓ The delay created documented TAN cash-flow pressure.
- ✓ General Fund capacity fell materially by FY2025.

Not supported now

- ✗ The identities of the unnamed March participants.
- ✗ Criminal conduct, fraud, or another specific illegality.
- ✗ A recruitment-motive theory.
- ✗ That all reserve decline was digest-caused.
- ✗ That temporary billing itself equals overbilling.
- ✗ A complete gross-to-net digest loss.
- ✗ That TAN principal was a loss.

Five document packages—not a broad fishing expedition

PRIORITY 1

March meeting record

Agenda, minutes, recording, attendees, and any percentage-limit request or directive.

PRIORITY 2

Sane's June 24 package

Signed letter, parcel population, calculations, and the basis for the 800+/7,000+ statements.

PRIORITY 3

DOR review file

Performance-review report, transmittal, deficiencies, corrections, responses, and approval dates.

PRIORITY 4

Temporary-to-final reconciliation

Original and amended bills, refunds, credits, additions, unpaid balances, collections, and GL postings.

PRIORITY 5

Parcel and budget change history

Named development parcels, assessment changes, correspondence, budget drafts, amendments, and transmittals.

READY

Narrow DOR request

Six existing-record categories; no broad email search, no taxpayer records, no CC. Draft remains unsent.

The documentary spine

Every material claim in the deck points to one or more records below.

12 PRIMARY SOURCES

- P1-3

Georgia DOR digest exports, 2022-2024
Whitfield rows 1715, 1724, 1741; M&O column PD; hashes in source register.
- P4-5

DOR annual reports, 2024-2025
Performance review, ratio deficiency, penalty, and millage tables.
- P6

Superior Court temporary-collection order
Civil Action File 24-CI-1294; findings and ordered ¶¶1-5.
- P7-8

City resolution and assessor release
Temporary-digest proposal and replacement-assessment process.

- P9

Whitfield County FY2023 ACFR
Pre-failure balances, collection schedule, and clean audit context.
- P10

Whitfield County FY2024 ACFR
Fund flow and year-end-close finding.
- P11

Whitfield County FY2025 ACFR
Comparative balances, TAN, Note 22, and finding 2025-001.
- P12

Approved FY2026 operating budget
\$62.229M revenue, \$67.118M expenditures, \$4.889M fund balance.

A documented public-record review—not an audit opinion

What was done

Official records were downloaded and inspected; exact cells/pages were recorded; arithmetic was independently reproduced; reporting and allegations were kept in separate evidence classes.

What was not done

No county GL, parcel-level roll, refund register, DOR case file, March recording, or signed Sane letter was available. No interviews were treated as sworn evidence.

How to update

Add new records to the source register, update the claims matrix first, then revise the deck. Never overwrite the evidence class simply because a narrative becomes more persuasive.

Resident takeaway: Whitfield County's 2024 digest breakdown is real, consequential, and documented. The remaining job is to quantify the digest-specific effects and identify who requested what—without turning unanswered questions into accusations.